

10, The "Orientalization" of Rome Possessed Both an Active Monarchical Aspect and a Passive Aspect Driven by Social Development

Based on the preceding discussions, we can now form a vastly more comprehensive understanding of the entire history of Byzantium.

The **Near East** is not only the cradle of human civilization but also the geographical pivot of the Eurasian landmass. Ever since the earliest batch of cities in human history emerged here, commercial activities and international trade have consistently played an exceedingly vital role across the entire region; the massive volume of commercial documents inscribed on clay tablets is ample proof of this.

The circulation sustained by commerce and trade is not only the very reason Byzantium achieved its "longevity," but perhaps even the formation of the concept of the "Byzantine Empire" itself owes its existence to it.

For instance, one easily notices that the "**Orientalization**" (东方化) of the Roman Empire obviously did not commence merely after the partition of the Eastern and Western empires, but rather unfolded across practically the entire imperial period of Rome. Traditionally, people's explanation for this issue is that the Eastern Mediterranean world boasted a profound history, advanced culture, and a highly developed economy, possessing an irresistible allure for Roman rulers. Therefore, Rome's ideology and culture increasingly (*and proactively*) gravitated toward the East, eventually leading the locus of ruling power to gradually shift eastward as well.

This explanation clearly reveals one aspect of "Orientalization." However, we absolutely must not forget that from an economic perspective, "Orientalization" obviously possessed another distinct dimension.

Not only did a **classical empire** itself rely heavily on developed circulation (*hence the proliferation of cities*), but Rome, as an empire expanding outward from a city-state, retained numerous traditions from its city-state era within its original institutional framework. Thus, it is vividly apparent that urban civic life constituted an indispensable component of the order Romans considered inherently natural and proper.

Yet, no matter how glorious Rome was, it could never transcend the immutable laws of social development. **When Rome's classical society developed to its absolute zenith, feudalizing factors inevitably surfaced.**

Historians can effortlessly observe that during the late Roman Empire, this colossal regime experienced the exact same phenomenon that the Eastern Han Dynasty experienced over two centuries prior: the explosive proliferation of the **manorial economy** (庄园经济), both in the western and eastern halves of the empire!

Therefore, we can place ourselves in the shoes of the Roman ruling elites of that era, and even pretend to be the rulers during the Crisis of the Third Century, to easily comprehend their perspective. Although the people of that era could not possibly have possessed an accurate understanding of the **feudalization** process, let alone know where feudalization would drag the world, one phenomenon they could definitively observe was this: **Urban life was visibly decaying across the entire expanse of the empire!**

The turmoil of the third century exacerbated people's anxieties. They likely hypothesized that there existed some intrinsic connection between the decay of urban life and political turbulence (*and looking back from our modern perspective, this was obviously correct*). Rome's political tradition was fundamentally inseparable from urban life; the official designation of this regime was "*The Senate and People of Rome*" (Senatus Populusque Romanus / SPQR). **If the city ceased to exist, where, then, would the Senate be?**

Observers have every reason to suspect that the Roman rulers of that era harbored an intense desire to restore their past glory. Their shift was not a conscious pivot toward the East, but rather a conscious endeavor to **preserve Rome's own political traditions!**

Consequently, the imperial rulers observed the following dynamic: Although urban life was decaying across the entire empire, the magnitude of this decay was markedly smaller in the East. **This was because commercial activities and international trade** (*of course, trade itself is a form of commercial activity; I continuously single it out here to emphasize its specific role, particularly in generating circulation*) **effectively "hedged against" (对冲掉) a portion of the impact of feudalization!**

Simultaneously, the geopolitical characteristics of the city of Rome itself underwent a monumental mutation. When the entire periphery of the Mediterranean was enveloped in a **classical society** characterized by highly developed cities and a **commodity economy**, Rome's geographical centrality largely represented its central position within the nation's economic activities.

However, once **feudalization** commenced, a duality emerged. On one hand, commercial and trade factors in the eastern half of the empire hedged against part of feudalization's impact. On the other hand, the rapid advancement of **feudalization** in the western half of the empire severely crippled local economic activities and severed economic ties with other regions—after all, a paramount characteristic of an early **feudal society** is a **natural economy** (自然经济)!

Although I am unaware if any scholar has ever completed such an exercise, suppose we plotted the state of circulation within the Roman Empire at two distinct timestamps: 100 AD and 350 AD. If we used the density of lines to represent the volume of circulation, it is effortless to deduce that, from the perspective of circulation volume, the empire's "**centre of mass**" (质心 / economic center of gravity) in 350 AD was glaringly far further east than it was in 100 AD, steadily drifting away from the city of Rome—the very birthplace of the empire!

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In this way, we witness the other side of Rome's "Orientalization" process: It was not a move to discard Rome's intrinsic traditions, but precisely the opposite—to safeguard Rome's intrinsic traditions, the imperial rule inevitably had to shift eastward! (*Beyond preserving Rome's traditions, "Orientalization" was also inevitably about preserving the traditions of a classical bureaucratic empire. Urban civic life is both a hallmark of **classical society** and a crucial sustaining factor for a **classical bureaucratic state**).*

As the Emperor and the ruling apparatus relocated to the East, they had no choice but to compromise with Eastern cultural traditions—such as declaring the legalization of Christianity. Over time, it appeared as though every inherent fixture of the East had been absorbed by the empire. In terms of political institutions, religion, and language, it exhibited such glaring differences from the original empire that ruled from Rome that it was derisively dubbed the "Greek Empire" by mischief-makers, or by the name we commonly use today: the Byzantine Empire.

As for where the "New Rome" should be constructed after abandoning the old one? It obviously had to be a location that could best sustain circulation and urban life, while simultaneously being easily defensible against the impact of **feudalization**—an impact the empire dreaded, yet knew was inevitable. For instance, one easily notices that **feudalization** means not only urban decay but also "**castellation**" (堡垒化 / **encastellation**). This does not merely mean that emerging feudal lords ruled their domains from impregnable fortresses; even within the surviving **classical society** of the Near East, urban morphology mutated. Cities shrank in scale, relocated from plains and valleys to easily defensible slopes, and were fortified with defensive structures like city walls.

During that era (*what Western scholars term **Late Antiquity** / 古典时代晚期*), what place in the entire world could simultaneously satisfy the requirements of building a metropolis, occupying a supreme position for commercial and trade activities, while simultaneously possessing absolute geographical superiority for military defense?

I believe that even a profoundly learned scholar who has traversed the four corners of the earth could not find a better location than Constantinople! **The birth of the Byzantine Empire was precisely the manifestation forged by the collision of two opposing movements: the universal progression of feudalization, and the Near East's developed commercial activities hedging against that very feudalization.**

However, as demonstrated by the ultimate annihilation of Byzantium, even though Rome dodged the shockwaves of the first wave of **feudalization** through its eastward strategic retreat, the decay of urban life and the unfolding of **feudalization** remained inexorably unstoppable.

The city-state traditions, which had somewhat survived in the Roman Empire due to the prosperity of urban economies during the classical period, vanished entirely. In the beginning, Constantinople indeed possessed a Senate, but its power grew increasingly feeble until it vanished completely from public view. Latin slogans ceased to be used, and eventually, the Latin language itself was forgotten in the Eastern Empire.

Even though Byzantium raked in astronomical fortunes through trade due to its divinely blessed geographical location, the burgher class (市民阶层)—as a faction capable of playing a pivotal role in national policy—ultimately exited the historical stage. **The Nika riots (尼卡暴动) wrote the final page in the glorious history of city-state citizenry dating back to ancient Greece.**

Consequently, many lament: *"Citizens were reduced to subjects. This Eastern Empire learned nothing else from its neighbors further east, but perfectly mastered the arts of castrating men and forcing them to kneel."*

In the Eurocentric perspective, this mutation of Byzantium is viewed as a drift toward "**Oriental Despotism**" (东方专制主义).

However, we must point out that there is essentially no such thing as "Oriental Despotism." It is merely that Greece and Rome, due to historical and geographical reasons, possessed extremely developed commercial activities. Merchants and burghers played a vastly larger role there than in other regions, allowing the political model of the city-state to be somewhat prolonged. In the geographically vastly different "East," the traditions of the city-state had long since become untraceable following the demise of the city-states themselves.

The participation of merchants and burghers in politics can effectively curb despotism. This is not only because their occupations render them the group with the strongest awareness of rights in the pre-feudal era—highly valuing credibility and contracts, and capable of fighting for their interests from relatively flexible standpoints. Furthermore, given the level of societal plurality sustainable by the productive forces and consciousness of that era, having multiple factions participating in the political game is never a bad thing. After all, it was difficult to have so many political factions that society plunged into total chaos! *(Of course, we cannot rule out the possibility that a class with shared interests might splinter into numerous small, personality-driven cliques; but if this results in severe consequences, it fundamentally constitutes an organizational failure).*

For example, it is easy to imagine: if a state possesses exactly two primary, antagonistic interest groups, the monarch can easily expand his own power by playing them against each other (*a balancing act between two factions*). Rulers during the transitional phase between two class societies would constantly employ this maneuver (*of course, sometimes this balance also exists between the ruling class and the ruled class*).

But if the number of major interest groups reaches three or four, then there exist diverse possibilities for alliances and confrontations among them (*especially since merchants and burghers can adopt highly flexible positions*). This embodies what the Chinese often call "**uniting the weak to attack the strong**" (合众弱以攻一强), rather than a two-party hostility where the weaker side can only desperately seek the monarch's favoritism. Under these circumstances, it becomes astronomically more difficult for the monarch to expand his power by pandering to both sides (左右逢源)!

Therefore, Byzantium's increasing drift toward "Oriental Despotism" was undoubtedly a reconfiguration of the superstructure triggered by mutations in the economic base. **It absolutely cannot be entirely blamed on the subjective actions of Byzantine emperors pursuing the despotic power enjoyed by their Persian peers.**

In fact, one will observe that the Byzantine monarchs from the 7th century onward fundamentally lacked the mature mechanisms possessed by the emperors of the **restoration-bureaucratic** Chinese empires to maintain despotic rule—mechanisms forged through a perfected bureaucratic system and designed to antagonize the landlord class. Let alone suppressing ambitious warlords in the provinces, the Byzantine emperors often struggled even to cope with conspiracies behind their own palace walls (萧墙之内的阴谋)! **For the emperors of the Song, Ming, and Qing dynasties, such a degree of imperial impotence would be utterly unimaginable.**

10, 罗马的“东方化”既有君主主动的一面，也有社会发展引起的被动的一面

基于以上讨论，我们对于拜占庭的整个历史就能够有一个更为全面的认识。近东地区不仅仅是人类文明的中心，同时也是欧亚大陆的枢纽位置。自从这里出现人类历史上最早的一批城市以来，商业活动和国际贸易始终在整个地区扮演了非常重要的角色，大量写于泥板上的商业文书足以证明这一点。商业和贸易所维持的流通不仅仅是拜占庭得以“长寿”的原因，甚至拜占庭帝国这个概念的形成也可能归功于此。例如人们很容易注意到，罗马帝国的“东方化”显然不是东西帝国分治之后才开始的，而是发生于近乎整个罗马的帝国时期。人们在传统上对于这个问题的解释是，东地中海世界的历史悠久，文化先进，经济发达，对于罗马的统治者来说具有无法抗拒的吸引力。因此罗马的思想和文化上越来越（主动地）向东方靠拢，到最后统治也逐渐向东方转移。

这种解释显然揭示了“东方化”的一个方面，但是我们不应该忘记从经济角度来看“东方化”显然存在着另一个方面。不仅是古典帝国本身依赖发达的流通（因此城市发达），罗马作为一个从城邦扩张而来的帝国，其原有体制保留了不少城邦时期的传统，因此人们很容易看出，城市生活构成了罗马人所认为理所应当的秩序不可或缺的一部分。可罗马再伟大也不能超出社会发展规律，当罗马的古典社会发展至极点的时候，封建化因素不可避免地出现了。历史学家可以很容易注意到，在罗马帝国晚期，这个庞大的政权发生了和两个多世纪前的东汉一模一样的现象，那就是庄园经济的蓬勃发展，无论是在帝国的西部还是东部。于是我们可以设身处地地思考一下当年罗马的统治精英如何看待世界的变化，甚至假装自己是三世纪危机时期的统治者就不难理解。当年的人们虽然不可能准确地理解封建化这个过程，更不知道封建化会把世界引向何方，但是他们一定能够观察到的事是，城市生活在帝国的整个疆域内正在衰退。三世纪的动乱又加剧了人们的不安情绪，他们或许会认为城市生活的衰退和政治动乱具有某种内在联系（当然站在现在的角度看这显然是对的）。罗马的政治传统离不开城市生活，这个政权的正式名称就是“元老院与罗马人民”（*Senatus Populusque Romanus*），如果城市不复存在，那么元老院又能在哪里呢？

观察者有理由怀疑，当年的罗马统治者有一种光复旧日荣光的愿望，这里不是为了有意识向东方靠拢，而是有意识地维护罗马自身的政治传统。于是帝国的统治者观察到了这么一点，虽然整个帝国境内的城市生活都在衰退，但是这个过程在东方明显幅度更小，因为在这里商业活动和国际贸易（当然贸易本身就是一种商业活动，我在此前一直把它拎出来说是想强调它的作用，特别是在创造流通上）对冲掉了一部分封建化的影响。与此同时，罗马这座城市本身的地缘特征发生了重大变化，当整个地中海周边都处于城市和商品经济发达的古典社会时，罗马在地理上的中心位置就很大程度上代表了它在全国经济

活动中的中心位置。但是当封建化开始之后，一方面帝国东部的商业和贸易因素对冲掉了封建化的一部分影响，另一方面帝国西部封建化的迅速发展又削弱了当地的经济活动和与其他地区的经济联系，毕竟封建化早期社会的一个重要特征就是自然经济。尽管我不知道有没有学者已经完成了这项工作，但是假如我们分别画出公元 100 年和公元 350 年两个时间点上罗马帝国境内的流通情况，线条数量的多寡用来表示流通量的大小，那么人们很容易想到从流通量来看，公元 350 年罗马帝国的“质心”（centre of mass）显然要比公元 100 年的时候偏东得多，越来越远离罗马城这个帝国兴起之地。

这样一来我们就看到了罗马“东方化”这一过程的另一面，不是为了抛弃罗马本身的传统，而恰恰是为了维护罗马本身的传统，帝国的统治必然要逐渐向东转移。（东方化除了维护罗马的传统以外，必然也是在维护古典官僚帝国的传统，城市生活既是古典社会的特征，也是古典官僚国家能够维持的因素）随着皇帝和统治机关前往东方，他们就不得不和东方的文化传统相妥协，例如宣布基督教合法化。久而久之，似乎东方一切固有的事物都被帝国接纳了，在政治体制，宗教，语言各个方面都与原先那个在罗马统治的罗马帝国显出极大的不同，以至于被好事者蔑称为“希腊帝国”或者现在我们常用的名字：拜占庭帝国。至于离开罗马之后新罗马应该建在何处呢？这显然是一个最能维持流通和城市生活的地方，同时也要便于应付帝国虽然不愿意面对，但是却不可能不到来的封建化的影响。例如人们很容易注意到封建化不但意味着城市衰退，同时也意味着“堡垒化”。这不只是说新兴封建领主在易守难攻的堡垒中统治领国，即使是在近东仍然延续的古典社会中，城市形态也发生了变化，例如规模缩小，从平原谷地转移到便于防御的坡地上，以及用城墙这样的防御工事设防。全世界什么地方在那个年代（就是西方学者说的古典时代晚期，Late antiquity）能够同时满足既要能够建设一个大都市，又处在商业和贸易活动的优越位置上，同时在军事防御上占尽地利呢？我认为即使是走遍五洲四海并且满腹经纶的人，也找不到一个比君士坦丁堡更好的地方。拜占庭帝国的诞生正是普遍的封建化进程与近东发达商业活动对冲封建化这两个相向的运动共同造就的。

但是就如拜占庭最终的灭亡所显示的，哪怕罗马通过向东方转进躲过了第一轮封建化浪潮的冲击，城市生活的衰退以及封建化的展开依旧不可阻挡。在古典时期因为城市经济繁荣而在罗马帝国多少有所延续的城邦传统消失了，最开始君士坦丁堡的确也有元老院，但是它的权力越来越微弱，最终消失在人们的视野里，拉丁文的标语不再使用，甚至拉丁语在东方帝国也被忘记。哪怕拜占庭因为其得天独厚的地理位置而在贸易中赚得盆满钵满，市民阶层作为一个在国家政策中能够发挥重要作用的一方还是退出了历史舞台，尼卡暴动（Nika riots）书写了自古希腊以来城邦公民辉煌历史的最后一页。因此许多人哀叹：公民变成了臣民，这个东方帝国从他更东方的邻居那里别的没学到，但是学会了阉割人和让人下跪。在以西欧为中心的视角中，拜占庭的这种变化被视为向“东方专制主义”靠拢。但是我们应当指出其实并不存在所谓的“东方专制主义”，只是希腊-罗马因为历史和地理原因商业活动极为发达，商人和市民起到了远比在其他地区更大的作用，城邦的政治模式被一定程度上延续。而在地理环境大为不同的“东方”地区，城邦的传统早就随着城邦的消亡而难以觅踪了。商人和市民参与到政治中来能够起到遏制专制主义的效果，不只是因为他们的原因是前封建时期权利意识最强，重视信誉和契约，能够以较为灵活的立场争取利益的团体。而且在当年的生产力和意识水平所能支持的社会多元度下，政治博弈中多一些势力参与并无坏处，毕竟很难有过多的政治派别以至于陷入混乱（当然我们不能排除明明有共同利益诉求的阶层内仍然分裂出一堆以个人为核心的小团体，但是如果因此造成严重后果，这属于组织上的失败）。

例如人们很容易想象，如果一个国家中具有两个主要的对立利益集团，那么君主很容易通过在双方之间进行制衡来扩张权力，两个阶级社会过渡阶段的统治者就会使用这一招数，当然有的时候平衡也存在于统治阶级和被统治阶级之间。但是如果重要的利益集团达到三个或者四个，那么他们彼此之间就存在结盟和对抗的不同可能（特别是商人和市民可以采取较为灵活的立场），也就是中国人常说的“合众弱以攻一强”，而不是在两方敌对的情况下在己方处于弱势的情况下只能寻求君主的偏袒。在这种情况下，君主想要通过左右逢源来扩大自己的权势就困难了很多。因此拜占庭越来越“东方专制主义”的确是由经济基础发生改变而引起的上层建筑的重构，不能完全归罪于拜占庭皇帝追求波斯同行那样的专制权力而主观上采取的行动。事实上人们也会看到，从七世纪开始的拜占庭君主根本不具备官僚复辟时期中华帝国的皇帝一样通过完善的官僚体制和对抗地主阶级的成熟手段来维护自己的专制统治，前者不要说压制地方上的野心家，甚至连萧墙之内的阴谋都难以应对，这对于宋、明、清的皇帝而言确实太难以想象了。